‘A Date Which Will Live in Infamy’

President Franklin D. Roosevelt · Address to Joint Session of Congress · December 8, 1941

Source: Franklin D. Roosevelt, Address to Congress Requesting a Declaration of War (Dec. 8, 1941), text via The American Presidency Project, UC Santa Barbara. Public domain.

Less than 24 hours after the Japanese surprise attack on Pearl Harbor (December 7, 1941), FDR addressed a joint session of Congress. The original draft began ‘a date which will live in world history’; FDR himself penciled in ‘infamy.’ Within an hour of the speech, Congress voted overwhelmingly (388–1 in the House; 82–0 in the Senate) to declare war on Japan. Germany and Italy declared war on the U.S. three days later.

Connect: WWII gave African Americans and women wartime opportunities that fed into the postwar civil rights and women’s movements. Trace ONE line from 1942 to a 1960s development.

Key Passages

Opening

Yesterday, December 7, 1941—a date which will live in infamy—the United States of America was suddenly and deliberately attacked by naval and air forces of the Empire of Japan. The United States was at peace with that Nation and, at the solicitation of Japan, was still in conversation with its Government and its Emperor looking toward the maintenance of peace in the Pacific.

On the scale of the attack

Yesterday the Japanese Government also launched an attack against Malaya. Last night Japanese forces attacked Hong Kong. Last night Japanese forces attacked Guam. Last night Japanese forces attacked the Philippine Islands. Last night the Japanese attacked Wake Island. And this morning the Japanese attacked Midway Island. Japan has, therefore, undertaken a surprise offensive extending throughout the Pacific area.

The request

No matter how long it may take us to overcome this premeditated invasion, the American people in their righteous might will win through to absolute victory. … I ask that the Congress declare that since the unprovoked and dastardly attack by Japan on Sunday, December 7, 1941, a state of war has existed between the United States and the Japanese Empire.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Japan's surprise attack on Pearl Harbor the day before (December 7, 1941) after years of rising tension over Japanese expansion in Asia.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Congress, which he asked to declare war, and the American public listening on radio.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	President Franklin Roosevelt, who had already been aiding the Allies and needed to unite a nation that had been divided over entering the war.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — compare two theaters of war: Identify ONE major difference between U.S. operations in the Pacific theater and in the European theater.
2. Why did FDR specifically list each Japanese attack rather than summarize?
3. Identify ONE specific economic or technological development that gave the U.S. an advantage in WWII.